The AI-First CRO

Book-to-Product Mapping

What Pete wrote. What Prism should build.

Prepared for Pete Mansel, CRO | February 2026
Author: Brad Towers, SE Lead UK/ANZ

Executive Summary

Pete's book, The AI-First CRO, lays out a complete operating philosophy for how a modern CRO should run revenue. It's not about dashboards or tools — it's about replacing reactive inspection with proactive governance, powered by AI signal detection and continuous improvement discipline (Kaizen).

Project Prism already implements several of the book's core ideas — deal health scoring, risk signal detection, competitor tracking, and portfolio-level intelligence. But the book reveals significant whitespace where Prism can go further, particularly around Pete's 20 Questions framework, absence signal detection, forecast bias analysis, and the Kaizen learning loop.

This document maps every actionable concept from the book to a specific Prism feature, categorised as BUILT (already in Prism), PARTIAL (started but incomplete), or NEW (not yet implemented). The goal: show Pete that Prism isn't just a dashboard — it's the technical manifestation of his operating philosophy.

1. Pete's Framework: The Three Pillars

The book is structured around three interconnected pillars that form the AI-First operating model. Everything in the book traces back to these:

Signal Architecture

The foundation. Pete argues CROs are drowning in lagging metrics (closed revenue, quota attainment) while ignoring leading signals that predict outcomes 60–90 days in advance. He defines four signal categories:

- **Activity Signals:** Meeting cadence, email response times, engagement patterns. Are buyers actively participating?
- **Sentiment Signals:** Language shifts in deal notes, buyer tone changes. Is enthusiasm fading?
- **Structural Signals:** Stakeholder changes, budget shifts, org restructures. Has the buying environment changed?
- **Absence Signals:** What's NOT documented. No champion identified, no next steps, silence after proposal. Pete calls these "the most dangerous and least monitored."

Decision Governance

The operating layer. Pete draws a sharp line between inspection ("what happened?") and governance ("what conditions must exist for this to close?"). Key principles:

- Forecasts should be diagnostic, not political. The system should tell you what's real.
- Shift from committing to outcomes to governing conditions. Don't ask "will this close?" — ask "are the conditions in place for this to close?"
- AI should eliminate the cost of asking, not the responsibility of deciding.

Kaizen Revenue Engine

The learning layer. Every loss should generate a countermeasure. Every win should be systematically replicated. Pete proposes a four-cadence rhythm: daily signals, weekly patterns, monthly systemic analysis, quarterly strategic review. The core discipline: "Problems must close, not circulate."

2. Feature Mapping: Book → Prism

Every actionable concept from the book, mapped to a Prism feature with implementation status.

Status	Prism Feature	Book Reference	Description
BUILT	**Deal Health Score**	Ch 4: Signal Architecture	Score each opportunity 0–100 based on activity recency, data completeness, stakeholder coverage, competitive clarity, and stage appropriateness.
BUILT	**Risk Signal Detection**	Ch 4: Absence Signals	Eight risk signal types: Ghost Signal, Champion Risk, Economic Buyer Gap, Stage Compression, Price Anchoring, Competitive Blind Spot, Implementation Anxiety, Partner Misalignment.
BUILT	**Competitor Intelligence**	Ch 4: Structural Signals	Track competitor mentions, win/loss ratios, FUD campaigns, and threat levels across the portfolio.
BUILT	**Win/Loss Theme Extraction**	Ch 6: Kaizen	LLM-powered extraction of recurring win themes (Workflow Automation, Scheduling Flexibility) and loss themes (Pricing vs Competition, Missing Asset Tracking).
BUILT	**Portfolio Aggregation**	Ch 5: Portfolio Decisions	Executive briefing with P1/P2/P3 recommendations, forecast confidence, and portfolio risk assessment.
BUILT	**Stage-Aware Analysis**	Ch 5: Governance	Simpro's 5-stage sales process encoded in system prompts. LLM checks required fields per stage and flags gaps.
PARTIAL	**Absence Signal Engine**	Ch 4: Absence Signals	Currently embedded in LLM prompts. Needs a dedicated UI panel showing what's missing per deal: no champion, no next steps, no competitor, no activity in 14+ days.
PARTIAL	**Sentiment Analysis**	Ch 4: Sentiment Signals	LLM extracts buyer sentiment from notes. Needs historical tracking to detect sentiment shifts over time.
PARTIAL	**Forecast Confidence**	Ch 5: Diagnostic Forecasts	AI confidence score exists in the dashboard. Needs deeper modelling: what % of commit pipeline would statistically not close based on historical patterns?
NEW	**The 20 Questions**	Ch 8: The 20 Questions	Dedicated dashboard view answering Pete's 20 questions. AI-generated answers refreshed weekly. THIS IS THE KILLER FEATURE.
NEW	**Ghost Pipeline View**	Ch 8: Question 2	Show "real" vs "reported" pipeline by stripping deals with no activity in 30+ days. Side-by-side comparison.

NEW	**Rep Health Scoring**	Ch 8: Question 3	Score reps by buyer engagement quality, not deal count. Which reps have the healthiest pipeline based on actual buyer signals?
NEW	**Pipeline Velocity Tracker**	Ch 8: Questions 4–5	Measure velocity by stage, not just overall. Where is pipeline actually accelerating vs. where we think it is?
NEW	**Forecast Bias Detection**	Ch 8: Question 9	Track which leaders/regions consistently over-forecast. Historical accuracy scoring per manager.
NEW	**Discount Intelligence**	Ch 8: Questions 12–13	Track discounting patterns by segment, stage, and competitor. Which discounts increase win rate but destroy margin or retention?
NEW	**Kaizen Learning Loop**	Ch 6: Kaizen Engine	Every loss generates a countermeasure. Track whether countermeasures are implemented and whether they work. Close the loop.
NEW	**Signal Decay Weighting**	Ch 4: Signal Freshness	Signals degrade over time. A champion identified 6 months ago is less reliable than one confirmed last week. Apply freshness weighting.
NEW	**Conditions Dashboard**	Ch 5, 10: Governance	Show leading indicators alongside lagging metrics. Shift from “what happened” to “are the conditions in place.”
NEW	**59-Day Playbook**	Ch 9: Transformation	Built-in onboarding flow following Pete’s 59-day AI-First CRO transformation playbook. Three phases with milestones.
NEW	**Revenue Kaizen Cadence**	Ch 6: Four Rhythms	Structured cadence: daily signal alerts, weekly pattern reports, monthly systemic analysis, quarterly strategic review.

3. Pete's 20 Questions → Prism Answers

The book's centrepiece. Pete defines 20 questions every AI-First CRO should be able to answer at any time. Here's how Prism answers each one:

#	Pete's Question	How Prism Answers It	Phase
1	Where are deals most likely to slip this quarter?	Deal Health Score + Risk Signal Detection. Deals scoring <50 with unresolved risk signals are flagged automatically.	Phase 1
2	What does pipeline look like without 30+ day inactive deals?	Ghost Pipeline View: side-by-side of reported vs. real pipeline with inactive deals stripped.	Phase 1
3	Which reps have healthiest pipeline by buyer engagement?	Rep Health Scoring: engagement-weighted pipeline quality, not just deal count or value.	Phase 1
4	Where is velocity actually improving vs. where we think?	Pipeline Velocity Tracker: stage-by-stage velocity trends with regional breakdown.	Phase 1
5	Which deals have velocity slowing below historical norms?	Stage duration anomaly detection: flag deals aging beyond 1.5x the historical average for their stage.	Phase 1
6	Where are stages accumulating beyond aging thresholds?	Funnel bottleneck analysis: highlight stages where deal count is growing but conversion is flat.	Phase 1
7	What commit pipeline statistically won't close?	Forecast Confidence Engine: historical pattern matching to predict realistic close rate on committed deals.	Phase 1
8	Is pipeline quality degrading faster than quantity growing?	Quality vs. Quantity trend: track deal health scores over time against pipeline growth.	Phase 2
9	Which leaders show highest forecast optimism bias?	Forecast Bias Detection: accuracy scoring by manager/region with historical trend.	Phase 2
10	What indicators best predicted forecast accuracy historically?	Pattern mining on closed deals: which signals at what stage most correlate with accurate vs. inaccurate forecasts.	Phase 2
11	If we froze demand gen, when would revenue failure become inevitable?	Pipeline runway calculation: current pipeline / burn rate = months of coverage.	Phase 2
12	Where is discounting clustering by segment/stage/competitor?	Discount Intelligence heatmap: discount patterns by dimension with win-rate correlation.	Phase 2
13	Which discounts increase win rate but destroy margin/retention?	Discount ROI analysis: correlate discount depth with win rate AND post-sale retention.	Phase 2

14	What pricing behaviour deviates from standard but is accepted?	Pricing anomaly detection: flag deals where discount exceeds norms without documented negotiation.	Phase 3
15	Which problems keep reappearing despite countermeasures?	Kaizen Loop tracking: recurring loss themes that haven't been resolved by previous countermeasures.	Phase 3
16	Where are we buying growth instead of earning it?	Growth quality analysis: heavy-discount wins vs. full-price wins by segment.	Phase 3
17	Which customers look healthy financially but show behavioural risk?	Post-sale signal detection: engagement decay, support ticket trends, expansion stalls.	Phase 3
18	What product signals precede expansion vs. contraction?	Product-usage to expansion correlation (requires product telemetry integration).	Phase 3
19	Where does local optimisation damage system performance?	Cross-region pattern analysis: when one region's discounting undermines another's pricing authority.	Phase 3
20	If we did nothing for 90 days, what would break first?	System stress test: model pipeline decay, coverage gaps, and revenue cliff scenarios.	Phase 3

4. Prioritised Implementation Roadmap

Based on the book mapping, here's what to build and in what order. Prioritised by: (a) alignment with Pete's philosophy, (b) data we already have, (c) demo impact for CIO/CRO audience.

Phase 1: Quick Wins (Next 2 Weeks)

These features use data we already ingest and extend what's already built:

1. **Absence Signal Panel** — Extract the absence detection from LLM prompts into a dedicated UI widget. Show per-deal: missing champion, no next steps, no competitor, stale activity. This is Pete's most emphasized signal category.
2. **Ghost Pipeline View** — Add a toggle showing "Reported Pipeline" vs. "Real Pipeline" (filtering deals with no activity in 30+ days). Simple, powerful, directly from Question 2.
3. **Stage Compliance Scorecard** — For each deal, show which required Salesforce fields are populated vs. missing for its current stage. We already have the stage definitions encoded in the system prompt.

Phase 2: Core New Features (Weeks 3–6)

These require new analysis logic but build on existing infrastructure:

4. **The 20 Questions Dashboard** — A dedicated view that answers Pete's 20 questions with AI-generated responses. Refreshed weekly with each analysis run. This is the feature that proves Prism is built on Pete's methodology.
5. **Pipeline Velocity by Stage** — Track how long deals spend in each stage and where they're accelerating or stalling. Trend lines over time.
6. **Forecast Bias Detection** — Compare forecasted outcomes vs. actuals by manager and region. Who consistently over-commits?
7. **Kaizen Learning Loop** — When a loss is recorded, the system prompts for a countermeasure. Track countermeasure implementation and effectiveness over time.

Phase 3: Strategic Differentiators (Weeks 7–12)

These are the features that make Prism genuinely unique:

8. **Discount Intelligence** — Correlate discounting patterns with win rates, retention, and margin. Surface where discounts are buying growth vs. earning it.
9. **Conditions Dashboard** — Replace "what happened" metrics with "are the conditions in place" indicators. The philosophical shift from inspection to governance, made visible.
10. **Revenue Kaizen Cadence** — Structured reporting rhythm: daily signal alerts, weekly pattern reports, monthly systemic analysis, quarterly strategic reviews. Each cadence generates different outputs.
11. **59-Day Transformation Tracker** — Built-in onboarding that follows Pete's 59-day playbook. Three phases with milestones, question unlocks, and progress tracking.

5. The Pitch to Pete

When presenting Prism to Pete, the narrative should be:

> *"Pete, you wrote the book on what an AI-First CRO should look like. We built the tool that makes it real. Every feature in Prism maps directly to a concept in your book — from Signal Architecture to Decision Governance to the Kaizen Learning Loop. Your 20 Questions aren't just a framework anymore; they're a live dashboard. This isn't a dashboard that tells you what happened. It's a governance engine that tells you what needs to happen next."*

The key selling points for Pete specifically:

- **His philosophy, operationalised:** Prism isn't generic BI. It's built on his three-pillar model.
- **Absence signals front and centre:** The feature he emphasised most — detecting what's NOT there — is a first-class citizen in Prism.
- **Governance over inspection:** Prism doesn't just report. It checks conditions, flags missing requirements, and recommends specific actions.
- **His 20 Questions, answered:** A dedicated view that answers the questions he says every CRO should know. Updated weekly. Powered by his own team's data.

What This Changes

If Pete sees Prism as the implementation of his book, it transforms the project from "a cool internal tool Brad built" to "the CRO's operating system." That's the difference between a side project and a company investment. Build for Pete's philosophy, and the executive sponsorship follows.